MUSIC

SEARCHING FOR THE SOUND

Kashmiri musician Faheem Abdullah's debut album* Lost; Found *is a collaborative effort

Over the past five years, Kashmir's small independent music scene has been making waves outside the Valley. Following in the footsteps of pioneers like MC Kash and Mohammad Muneem, a new generation of Kashmiri artists—such as Ahmer, Straight Outta Srinagar, Ali Saifuddin—are finding audiences in the Indian mainland and beyond, with music that blends global sounds with elements of Kashmiri culture. With his debut album *Lost; Found*, out on May 25, Faheem Abdullah stakes his claim as one of this scene's most exciting torchbearers.

The 26-year-old musician, writer and filmmaker grew up immersed in music, whether it's the devotional songs his mother would sing, or the Lucky Ali cassettes his uncle would always be listening to. His formative influences include the alternative-leaning pop-rock of bands like Jal, Roxen (both from Pakistan) and Agnee, as well as the Kashmiri folk music. "Growing up in Kashmir, we had equal exposure to both Indian and Pakistani music," he says. "And we took the best from both worlds."



Literature, particularly Urdu, is also a key inspiration. In fact, Abdullah (who also goes by the moniker 'The Imaginary Poet') was a writer long before he became a musician, and the influence of that pedigree is apparent in his old-world lyricism. 'Ishq', the lead single, borrows its lyrics about old-school love from a poem by Pakistani writer Amir Ameer, while the otherworldly 'Waavo' is inspired by a *sher* Abdullah's grandfather would recite.

"I am trying to tell all these different stories from my life," he says. "There's a song about separation, one about the bright side of Kashmir, and one about the dark side of love."

Lost; Found refers to the album's central concept—these are songs about feeling lost, and finding yourself. But it could also refer to Abdullah's genre-fluid approach, each song a different experiment as he looks for his definitive sound. In this quest, he drafted in a number of contemporaries from Kashmir. "I wanted to make the point that this can be a homegrown album... but still be very international in sound," he says. "It's about representation, a way to tell my listeners that I belong to this part of the world." ■

–Bhanuj Kappal

Rhythms of Nature



ARTIST AND MUSIC COMPOSER **GINGGER SHANKAR**'S LATEST SINGLE COMBINES SOUTH INDIAN MUSIC WITH INUIT THROAT SINGING

Gingger Shankar—the great-grandniece of the late Grammy award-winning Indian sitar virtuoso Pandit Ravi Shankar—is a firm believer in artist collaborations. No wonder, her latest single 'Ever So Lonely/ Eyes/ Ocean' with Inuit throat singer Charlotte Qamaniq—a reimagining of former English pop singer Sheila Chandra's iconic hit of the same name—amalgamates their individual vocal traditions. "I have always loved that song and decided to make it an ode to mother nature. Charlotte and I both picked various sounds from nature to create this song. We decided to do it a cappella so every single sound you hear is one of our voices," says Shankar.



FOR 'EVER SO LONELY/ EYES/ OCEAN', SHANKAR HAS COLLABORATED WITH CHARLOTTE QAMANIQ

"We wanted to show what the range and power of women's voices can sound like. The song covers four and a half octaves. It's quite special because it's the first time throat singing and south Indian music have been recorded together," she adds. The single that was released through Naughty Horses Records on Earth Day (April 22) took a month to complete.

Shankar, who is known for her compositions in films like *The Passion of the Christ*, *Charlie Wilson's War* and *And She Could Be Next*, is excited to share this new song through performances and a music video. "The video will be out in May and I am working on an a cappella album—with this being the first single. I also recently launched the Little Indian Girl Collective at SXSW film festival in Austin with Tara Houska and Rosario Dawson," she adds. "The collective tells stories of women who embody revolution through art." ■

–Geetika Sachdev